

Philadelphia museum closes despite campaign and temporary funding offer

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Philadelphia's Academy of Natural Sciences Museum has closed to the public, leaving families and supporters asking whether a major place for learning about nature can reopen. The closure was announced on September 1, with September 30 set as its final day.

Families made farewell visits throughout the month. For many, the museum had been part of childhood across several generations. Alexandria McCormick, visiting with her husband and six children, said her own visits had helped awaken her love of natural history.

Founded in 1812 and opened to the public in 1828, the Academy became the first place in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton in 1868. It also offered mammal displays, live animals and changing exhibitions.

Drexel University, which took financial responsibility for the Academy in 2011, says costs rose and attendance fell after the pandemic. Drexel has also faced financial difficulties connected partly to declining **enrollment**. The museum cut staff and hours in 2025 and later cancelled its 2026 summer camp.

Supporters organized rallies and a petition with more than 114,000 signatures. Some criticized the short notice and questioned whether enough had been done to prevent closure. Attendance surged during the final weeks, with **revenue** more than 20 times higher than the previous September.

Less than a week before closing, the William Penn Foundation offered a year of **bridge funding**. That means temporary financial support while a longer-term solution is explored. Drexel says it is considering working with the foundation, but would require a plan for lasting **financial stability** before considering reopening.

Philadelphia's city council plans public hearings to investigate the decision and possible solutions. It also proposed changing local **land-use** rules to make selling the building or converting it to other uses more difficult.

The Academy's collection contains more than 19 million specimens, including plant samples gathered by Lewis and Clark. Its 73,000 **holotype** specimens serve as scientific references for defining and naming species. Drexel says students and researchers will retain collection access, but what access the general public will have remains uncertain.

Word Treasure

enrollment -- The number of students attending a school or university.

revenue -- Money an organization receives before subtracting its costs.

bridge funding -- Temporary money that provides time to seek a longer-term solution.

financial stability -- Having dependable resources to cover costs over time.

land-use -- Related to how land and buildings may be used.

holotype -- Describing a specimen used as a reference for defining and naming a species.

Break it down

Opens with the closure announcement and final day.
Shows the museum's connection to families through McCormick's experience.
Summarizes the Academy's history and exhibits.
Describes financial difficulties and supporters' response.
Explains the bridge funding offer and city council proposals.
Ends with the scientific collection and unresolved public access.

Why it matters

The closure affects families' access to nature education and a major scientific collection. Temporary funding and public hearings could help explore solutions, but reopening is uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. When was the museum's closure announced?
 - (A) September 15
 - (B) October 1
 - (C) September 1
 - (D) September 30
2. What did Alexandria McCormick say about her childhood visits?
 - (A) They helped inspire her love of making music.
 - (B) They helped inspire her love of natural history.
 - (C) They helped inspire her love of playing sports.
 - (D) They helped inspire her love of writing plays.
3. How did revenue in the final weeks compare with the previous September?
 - (A) It was about twice as high.
 - (B) It stayed at about the same level.
 - (C) It was more than 20 times higher.
 - (D) It was less than half as high.
4. What would Drexel require before considering reopening?
 - (A) A plan for more changing exhibitions
 - (B) A plan for lasting financial stability
 - (C) A plan for additional farewell visits
 - (D) A plan for a larger dinosaur display
5. What would the proposed land-use changes make harder?
 - (A) Signing petitions or organizing public rallies
 - (B) Displaying mammals or showing live animals
 - (C) Selling the building or changing its use
 - (D) Studying specimens or naming new species
6. What purpose do the holotype specimens serve?
 - (A) They are financial records used to plan museum budgets.
 - (B) They are scientific references for defining and naming species.
 - (C) They are visitor records used to compare museum attendance.
 - (D) They are building plans used to design changing exhibitions.

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Alexandria McCormick: Said visiting the museum as a child helped awaken her love of natural history.
2. Drexel University: Reports rising costs and falling attendance after the pandemic. It is considering the foundation's offer but says reopening would require lasting financial stability.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):